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God's Wider Presence

Key takeaways from this chapter:

- Psychological practitioners are helped by a broader notion of God's presence in the world.
- The Spirit of God is present and active outside the church and without reference to Jesus Christ.
- The Spirit is not a disembodied ghost but the divine breath of life.
- God is actively involved in our colleagues' and clients' lives long before and long after our own involvement.

Meet John. He's eighteen years old. He can be sarcastic, temperamental, and disengaged at times, but, just as often, he's inquisitive, kind, and self-reflective. He plans on going to college at some point in the future, but he really isn't interested in taking on the kind of student debt he's heard so much about. In the meantime, he's pretty content working at a local coffee shop and playing bass with the band he formed with his friends from high school.

Like many in his generational cohort, John also lives with a base level of anxiety that manifests itself in semi-frequent bouts of depression. It's not that he hates his life or can't recognize how, as a middle-class White kid from the suburbs, his problems are qualitatively different than most of the humans on the planet. If anything, that's part of the problem. On the surface, it doesn't appear that he would have much to fret about, and he knows it, but

he can't seem to shake the pervasive sense of dread that serves as the backdrop for his every waking moment.

Because it's Tuesday, John is your first client of the day. Scanning through your files in preparation for your time together, you are reminded that, like an increasing number of his contemporaries, John is a religious "none." He doesn't identify with any religious tradition and never really has. He was raised in a nonreligious home, and while he isn't antagonistic toward any specific religion or people of faith in general, religion has no bearing on his daily life—at least not in any significant way. If pressed, John would probably say that he just doesn't see what the fuss is all about. Religious beliefs and practices are less than irrelevant to him. They are simply beside the point.

John is not an outlier. In fact, as you sit knee-to-knee with him on this Tuesday morning, you realize that most of your clients, whether they profess some kind of religious faith or not, share a profile similar to John. Unlike John, they may identify as Christian and even engage in some of the more formal practices that being a Christian often entails (e.g., church attendance, financial giving, and observance of certain holidays). But for all intents and purposes, this identity has no real purchase on the way they live, much less how they understand their lives. Even those whose Christian faith is central to their identity come to you first and foremost for psychotherapy and not pastoral counseling, so they have no real expectation that religion would or should come into play.

Recognizing that this kind of religious diversity is part of what makes US society so rich and textured, the American Psychological Association code of ethics has made it clear that, regardless of a client's religious commitments (or lack thereof), psychologists are to be "aware of and respect cultural, individual and role differences, including those based on . . . religion . . . and consider these factors when working with members of such groups." At the same time, "In their work-related activities, psychologists do not engage in unfair discrimination based on . . . religion . . . or any basis proscribed by law."[1] In other words, although psychologists must be sensitive to

the various ways in which religion and spirituality might be functioning in a client's life, it would never be appropriate for therapists to impose their beliefs and values on clients, or to provide differential treatment to individuals who may not subscribe to those same beliefs and values.

In some respects, formal codes of conduct like these make things fairly straightforward. It can often be helpful for therapists to know exactly what to do when attempting to navigate real-world complexities. If a client wants to talk about their religion or spirituality, great. If not, no problem. In fact, even though it's perfectly understandable for clients to turn to their therapist for guidance on matters of faith, they are likely to be disappointed when they do. After all, clinical psychologists are trained in forms of psychotherapy and not in theology. Only in rare cases are they also members of the clergy.[2]

Complicating matters, however, is the way in which formal codes of conduct, although at times helpful, can mask (and perhaps even sublimate) much deeper issues. As Kenneth Pargament has pointed out, contemporary models of psychotherapy have inherited a deep suspicion regarding religion and spirituality from the psychological paradigms that emerged during the twentieth century, most notably behaviorism and psychoanalysis.[3] According to Pargament, this disciplinary skepticism—and, at times, outright hostility—has generated thin and superficial notions of religious faith among many (if not most) psychotherapists in practice today. What is more, because the great majority of psychology programs in the United States provide virtually no training in religion or spirituality, graduates of these programs are largely unprepared to help, much less understand, clients whose religious life and practice are central to their identity.[4] Nevertheless, regardless of the gaps in their training or their personal convictions, APA guidelines stipulate that therapists must address their clients' religious and spiritual concerns in the midst of psychotherapy when appropriate.[5] It is in part for this very reason that psychologists like David A. Steere have advocated

strongly for all mental health workers—from psychotherapists, psychologists, and psychiatrists, to social workers, pastoral counselors, and nurses—to accommodate a spiritual dimension in their work.[6]

To be sure, these are significant challenges for anyone studying to become a clinical psychologist, but students of Christian faith face an even larger and more pressing question from the start—one that is distinctly theological. Namely, in what sense does their work as mental health professionals relate to the ongoing presence and activity of God in the world? Do their current studies or their future roles in the field of psychology have anything to do with the ways in which God is involved in their own lives, or are these wholly separate projects that, for necessary reasons, need to be kept free from all things theological? As it concerns a client like John, in what ways (if any) might God be involved in *his* journey toward healing and mental health? For that matter, what does it look like for any of us to participate faithfully in what God is doing in our clients' lives, even in those cases when the topics of faith, spirituality, and/or religion are, for good reason, never broached?

In our estimation, the only way to answer these questions without throwing our hands up and concluding that the realms of psychology and theology should remain wholly distinct is to develop a much broader and more generous notion of God's presence.[7] In fact, a more robust pneumatology (i.e., a doctrine of the Spirit) is critical for recognizing and affirming the ways in which humans are able to collaborate with God's activity in the broader world, especially in domains (e.g., the therapeutic context) that are not explicitly Christian, religious, or even theistic. While the doctrine of creation provides a foundation for conceptualizing the relationship between psychology and the Christian faith, pneumatology is the doctrine that can help students of psychology recognize how God's action is carried out through human involvement in clinical and research psychology.

In this chapter, then, we develop a biblically grounded pneumatology that conceives of the Spirit primarily in terms of the

presence and ongoing activity of God's Spirit in the world, and not merely as the Spirit of Christ and his church. In doing so, we will ask two basic questions: What is God up to? and How do we join in?[8]

A God without Borders

In the previous chapter, we briefly considered a handful of distinct but overlapping theological concepts: general revelation, common grace, and natural theology. These are related topics, to be sure, and they each provide a slightly different way of thinking not only about how God discloses Godself in and through the natural realm but also about how God structures, orders, and actively upholds the whole of the created order. Indeed, one of our operating assumptions is that the self-disclosure of the trinitarian God in creation is not simply an interesting aside to the "real" truth we find in Scripture but rather serves as the necessary condition for humans to discover anything at all about God's wisdom, beauty, and creativity in their exploration of the world we inhabit. Without any risk of overstatement, none of the claims we are advancing in this book regarding the theological significance of the psychological sciences hold up without a well-rounded conception of the trinitarian God revealing Godself in and through the created order.

However, we also noted that, depending on the historical and denominational context in which it was discussed, each concept has proven to be somewhat problematic. For example, motivated by their commitment to *sola Scriptura*, theologians in the Reformed tradition have explored at great length the numerous occasions in which the biblical witness points toward God's revelatory work in the world.[9] Yet, more often than not, these theologians have tended to understand this mode of God's revelation as a "cup half empty."[10] When compared to the special revelation found in Scripture and the person and work of Jesus Christ, the knowledge of God that is disclosed through general revelation is thought to be at best ambiguous, vague, and inchoate, and at worst, prone to distortion and abuse by a sin-scarred humanity.[11] For many, the distorting

effects of human sin are simply too great a hurdle to overcome, which means that the primary function of general revelation is to prepare people to receive the more complete, saving knowledge of God in Christ. From this perspective, general revelation can do little more than reveal to humans that they are without excuse for denying that which creation has routinely made clear to them (Rom. 1:20) and thus stand condemned before a righteous God.

In addition to this pervasive skepticism regarding the human capacity to deduce any kind of reliable or trustworthy knowledge about God from the created order, some theologians have also raised legitimate concerns about whether the doctrine of general revelation involves God at all. The reason Karl Barth said "*Nein!*" so forcefully to the natural theology espoused by his fellow German theologians was not because he had a limited vision of how God worked in the world but because he was wary of any theological project that would suggest humans could, through unaided reason or by simply observing the natural order, arrive at any kind of knowledge of God.[12] For it to be revelation, said Barth, something more than mere human curiosity needs to be in play. Only God can reveal Godself. To suggest otherwise runs the risk of humans "discovering" a God who looks an awful lot like a projection of themselves.[13]

Although we don't share all the concerns our theological forebears articulated, we highlight them in order to situate our understanding of God's wider presence[14] within the historic theological tradition. For example, we agree with the Reformed theologians that sin clouds our vision and that its distorting effects should not be taken lightly. But just because we see "through a glass darkly" does not mean that we should automatically distrust, discount, or devalue the truths we discover in and through our encounter with the world. If this were the case, then neither should we trust the truths we encounter in Scripture, for they too are filtered through our sin-marred faculties. In our present state, sin is of course a given, but to borrow a phrase from Emil Brunner, there remains a "point of contact" between God and humanity.[15]

This point of contact is more than a mere interface by which theological knowledge is transmitted. Rather, it implies the coming together of two subjects or, in the words of Martin Buber, an "I-Thou" encounter.[16] To speak of God's wider presence in this way is to shift the frame of reference from what humans know *about* God to the means by which humans come to *know* God personally. It is to acknowledge that, as the Third Person of the Trinity, the Spirit of God is always already present and active in human life, meeting people in the midst of concrete, lived situations. Just as Barth suggested, there simply is no sense in which humans, through their own efforts, could ever attain a knowledge of God without God's ongoing involvement in their various pursuits. But in contrast to Barth, our operating assumption is that the Spirit of God is pervasively present in the world rather than standing at an "infinite qualitative distance" from humanity, which means that God is not simply waiting around passively for humans to discover some generic set of divine attributes through unaided human reason.[17] The Spirit of God is actively calling human creatures to participate as co-laborers in God's creative project, inviting them to "search for God and perhaps grope around for him and find him" (Acts 17:27).

These key differences notwithstanding, we remain fully in line with the broader Protestant tradition in our commitment to a biblically grounded understanding of the Spirit's wider presence. Indeed, this commitment to grappling with the biblical text and its testimony to God's common grace is perhaps one of the Reformed tradition's greatest contributions to contemporary constructive theology. For, more so than any other source, it is the biblical witness that not only calls into question any overly narrow or restrictive view of God's work in the world but also challenges us to take seriously the variety of ways in which God is very much present and active outside the church and without reference to Jesus Christ.

Although space will not permit an exhaustive account of the biblical data, we can identify at least three domains in which God reveals Godself in Scripture, each of which has been outlined by Robert K. Johnston in *God's Wider Presence*:

> It is my contention that God's wider revelation is not something that is available to all humanity through the *imago Dei* based on our human capacity. Rather, with [Karl] Barth, we must say, first, that revelation always needs the Spirit as Revealer—it is event. Secondly, with [Friedrich] Schleiermacher, general revelation is not first of all accessible because of our rationality, but rather is rooted in that intuition of Something or Someone beyond us and our feeling that results from this encounter. And third, with [C. S.] Lewis . . . general revelation is not merely a trace, something largely insignificant given Christ or incomprehensible because of our sin, but the experience of the wider Presence of God through his Spirit mediated through *creation, conscience*, and *human culture*.[18]

Creation, conscience, and human culture: let us turn briefly to each of these modes by which the Spirit is present in our lives before considering what it might look like to participate with the Spirit in and through the work of clinical psychology.

Creation

From the book of Job (32:8) to various psalms (8:3–4; 19:1–6; 93:3; 97:6) to the stories found in the Acts of the Apostles (14:15–17; 17:24–28) to the opening chapters of Romans (1:18–20), Scripture is filled with references to God's revelatory presence mediated through nature and the created order more generally. When the "heavens declare the glory of God" (Ps. 19:1 NIV), or when the psalmist looks to the heavens and sees "the work of [God's] fingers" (Ps. 8:3 NIV), no caveat is provided. There is no suggestion by the biblical authors nor is there anything about the narrative context of these passages that would indicate the knowledge creation provides regarding God's creative work is incomplete or inadequate. Its function is not merely to "prepare" humans to receive a more complete form of revelation; rather, the Spirit's pervasive presence in nature is simply a given. Thus, the divine *ruach* (i.e., spirit) hovering over the watery abyss during creation (Gen. 1:2) is the same Spirit who actively sustains and upholds God's ongoing creative project. Nothing is more fundamental. For the biblical authors, the Spirit of God constitutes material reality itself.

Conscience

In addition to the heavens and earth proclaiming the work of God, the biblical text also indicates that God is actively present in the human heart, even among those who are neither part of the covenant community nor privy to the special revelation found in the person of Christ. For instance, according to the apostle Paul, "When Gentiles, who do not possess the law, do instinctively what the law requires, these, though not having the law, are a law to themselves. They show that what the law requires is written on their hearts, to which their own conscience also bears witness; and their conflicting thoughts will accuse or perhaps excuse them on the day when, according to my gospel, God, through Jesus Christ, will judge the secret thoughts of all" (Rom. 2:14–16 NRSV).

There is far too much in these few verses to fully unpack here. What we can say is that Paul's larger argument in Romans underscores the fact that all have sinned—everyone. No one, whether Jew or gentile, is worthy of God's unmerited grace. But within that argument, in which we are all sinners, Paul is both honest and humble enough to say that some of us who know God and fail to do God's will are put to shame by those who don't have God's special revelation. They may not have any knowledge of Jesus or the law, but they nonetheless act consistent with God's revelation. What the law requires is "written on their hearts," and their conscience bears witness to this reality. Paul's point is not that we don't need Jesus or that special revelation is not essential. His point is rather that people outside the covenant community of Israel and outside the Christian faith can and do know God's will and, more important, they do it. To borrow a turn of phrase from biblical scholar Robert Jewett, these "righteous Gentiles" are able to sense and discern what God has written on their hearts and to respond appropriately.[19] Another way to put it is that they are respond-able to the presence and activity of the Spirit of God. And according to Paul, somehow, and in some way, they will be accused or excused based on how they respond when the Spirit pricks their conscience.

Culture

One of the distinguishing marks of what it means to be human is that we are culture-makers through and through. As evolutionary psychologists frequently remind us, it's almost as if we cannot help but make something of the world we inhabit. Humans construct the very niches that, in turn, form and inform our development as individuals and as a species.[20] Theologically speaking, this stands to reason. Not only do humans "image" the Creator through their creative projects, but their culture-making activity serves as one of the primary means by which they are able to collaborate with God's creative project. In an important sense, God created humans to be not simply managers of creation but cocreators, ascribing to them the task of being "fruitful," multiplying, and filling the created order (Gen. 1:28). Known as the cultural mandate, humans are to "till" the soil and "keep" it, that is, to cultivate it (Gen. 2:15 NRSV). As visual artist Makoto Fujimura says so eloquently in his book *Culture Care*, "Culture is not a territory to be won or lost but a resource we are called to steward with care. Culture is a garden to be cultivated."[21]

When located within a larger theological framework of God's revelatory presence, human culture-making serves as an occasion in which God is not only present but actively collaborates with humans. In Exodus, it is the Spirit of God who fills the artisans and craftsmen responsible for both the construction and adornment of the tabernacle (Exod. 31:1–11; 36:8–13). But it is not merely artists in the covenant community who are in-spirited in this way. As Paul points out in his speech on the Areopagus, the same Spirit who filled the artisans building the tabernacle is the One who also inspired the Greek poets to create art that reflected the truth of God's pervasive presence: "In him we live and move and have our being" (Acts 17:28 NRSV). Rather than focus on how this poetry could only ever deliver "partial" knowledge about God or how the Athenians' minds were distorted by sin, Paul points out the ways in which the Spirit of God is already present and active in their creative works, even when those works of art were produced in a cultural context that knew nothing of the person and work of Jesus Christ or the God of Israel.

Not all biblical scholars agree that Paul was uncritically endorsing this Greek poetry. Nevertheless, there is no escaping the fact that now we have a series of cultural artifacts (i.e., poems), produced by non-Christian authors, included in the Christian canon as a testament to God's reality-encompassing presence (e.g., Acts 17:18). More to the point, though, by adopting this kind of posture toward a pre-Christian culture, Paul's approach serves as a helpful model for anyone hoping to participate in what the Spirit is up to in contemporary, post-Christian societies.

The Breath of God

We have only scratched the surface of the biblical evidence here, but there is plenty to reinforce the claim that the Spirit of God is indeed present and active far beyond the walls of the church and in places where the name of Jesus is never uttered. Still, even if we accept this basic premise as the starting point for a more robust pneumatology, the question remains as to what it would look like to contribute to or participate in the Spirit's ongoing project in the world. It is a question that of course pertains to every person of faith, no matter what their individual vocation happens to be. As the cultural mandate of Genesis suggests, we have all been entrusted with the task of co-laboring with God, called to cultivate our particular corner of the garden in such a way that it bears life. However, given that clinical psychologists and psychological scientists often operate in domains that, for legal and ethical reasons, are devoid of any explicitly Christian references, the question of how this kind of work contributes to the Spirit's work is particularly critical for students of psychology to consider.

For anyone whose imagination has been shaped by the Western intellectual tradition, the idea that humans might interact with any "spirit," much less the Spirit of God, may present certain difficulties, but this need not be the case. In contrast to the Latin *spiritus* or the German *geist, the biblical text has no conception of the human or divine spirit as disembodied ghosts or immaterial beings. Rather, the authors of the Hebrew Bible conceive of the Spirit of God as the*

divine ruach, which is best translated not as spirit but as wind, breath, or sustaining energy. Ruach is the breath of life that perpetually animates the whole of the created order (Eccles. 3:21; 11:5; 12:7), the irresistible force of the Creator's power, which ushers in both God's wrath and God's life-giving presence (Ezek. 13:13; 36:26–27).

According to Jürgen Moltmann, who developed one of the most influential pneumatologies of the twentieth century, *ruach* is at once "God's own creative power to give life, and the created ability to live enjoyed by all the living (Ps. 104:30)."[22] For Moltmann, the Spirit's creative work is not cut off from our embodied life in the natural world; rather, God's *ruach* serves as "the divine wellspring of life—the source of life created, life preserved and life daily renewed, and finally the source of the eternal life of all created being."[23] From a biblical perspective, then, there is a necessary blurring of the boundaries between the activities of God's Spirit and the human spirit. God's *ruach* not only brings the first humans to life by breathing into the dust (Gen. 2:7), it also "returns" to God when the lives of those creatures come to an end (Eccles. 12:7). According to the biblical testimony, it isn't that humans simply live their lives under their own power until the appointed time at which God determines they should no longer exist; it is rather that their every waking moment is animated and upheld by the Spirit of God who is actively breathing life into the world. In fact, as Psalm 104:29 (and even Ehud in Job 34:15) makes clear, if the Spirit were not present, there would be nothing and no one of which we could even speak, so much so that it would be more accurate to consider humans as in-spirited bodies.[24]

Importantly, though, while the biblical authors do indeed use the word *ruach* to talk about both the divine Spirit and the human spirit, they do not fully equate the human and divine spirit, nor do they completely collapse the distinction between the two. We too can picture our own spirits as a wind or a breath, like God's *ruach*, but it is a breath of a different sort. So, on the one hand, the biblical witness speaks of *ruach* as the Spirit of God in the world, but, on the

other hand, in speaking of humans and human creations, it often employs the image of *hevel*. This is the word that the preacher in Ecclesiastes repeats time and again, and it is often translated as "meaningless" or "vanity." But in that book and elsewhere, *hevel* is better translated as vapor, steam, or breath. Consider Psalm 39: "Surely everyone stands as a mere breath [*hevel*]. Surely everyone goes about like a shadow. Surely for nothing they are in turmoil [*hevel*]; they heap up, and do not know who will gather. . . . Surely everyone is a mere breath [*hevel*]" (vv. 5–6, 11 NRSV). In other words, the human is as fleeting and insubstantial as the condensation we see when we exhale a warm breath into the cold night air. Like the clearing of a fog or mist, as soon as it's here, it's gone.[25]

Of course, as long as there is no movement in the air (e.g., in a vacuum), a mist or vapor of this sort will remain suspended indefinitely. It is only under the force of a stronger wind—a stronger breath—that the mist seemingly disappears. In fact, though, the condensed water particles hovering together in the air are not destroyed or annihilated. Rather, they yield themselves; they give way to another breath. They are at once caught up in and dissipated by the wind. The vapor is still present, but in its disruption, it is re-created and reconstituted.[26]

This image of a fleeting vapor under the influence of the moving wind is particularly fitting for students of psychology considering how their research and clinical work might relate to the movement of God's Spirit, especially because many of their efforts with clients will likely never see the light of day and, even if they do, will seem fleeting at best. They are but a breath. As a consequence, the image of an ephemeral mist (*hevel*) interacting with a gale-force current (*ruach*) serves as a helpful metaphor for considering what it looks like to participate in God's ongoing project in the world. In doing so, it offers us a picture of what takes place any time the divine Spirit meets and merges with the human spirit.

The Spirit Animates

In the first place, as the breath of life, the Spirit of God serves as the animating force behind each and every one of our initiatives, from the remarkable to the mundane. Theologically speaking, no human activity takes place outside the Spirit's purview, and that includes the work of mental health professionals. Even if we wanted to section off some domain of life (e.g., clinical psychology) from the Spirit's influence, it would not be possible, for the *ruach Elohim* is a pervasive presence that animates the whole of our life in the world. Just as Psalm 139:7 rightly asks, "Where can I go from your spirit? Or where can I flee from your presence?" (NRSV). Here the psalmist is asking a far deeper question than whether an actual location might exist in which the Spirit is not already present. Rather, as the all-pervasive, animating force of life, the Spirit is actively present in our every proceeding as the internal structure that makes any and every human interaction possible.[27]

To use a term coined by John V. Taylor, as the animating force of life, the Spirit is the "go-between God," the One who creates the necessary conditions not only for us to be aware of the "other" in our midst but also for us to recognize the full potential of those sacred moments in which we encounter another person for who they truly are.[28] From this perspective, to ask how our various human projects (psychological or otherwise) would unfold in the Spirit's absence is as nonsensical as asking what a group of fictional literary characters might do in the absence of their author. The author doesn't merely intervene in the lives of these characters, occasionally influencing their otherwise self-sustaining activities; rather, the author constitutes the conditions for their very existence. Without the author's ongoing, creative involvement, there simply are no characters and there is no story. It is in this strong sense that the Spirit animates our lives and the world we inhabit.

The Spirit Disrupts

The idea of a vapor or mist giving way to a stronger wind might strike some as a fairly innocuous metaphor, but if we think of it in terms of God's Spirit engaging with the human spirit, a far more disruptive and unsettling picture emerges. For instance, it is not incidental that the most disruptive voices in Israel's history were the prophets and judges who, stirred by the Spirit of God, announced God's judgment on a hard-hearted and wayward people (Judg. 3:10; 6:34; 11:29; 13:25; Ezek. 11:5; Mic. 3:8; Zech. 7:12). If there is one thing the Spirit refuses to leave untouched, it's the status quo. In fact, disrupting our staid sensibilities is so central to the Spirit's ongoing work that, according to Walter Brueggemann, the primary role of the spirit-filled prophet is to invite disruption into our midst:

> The poetic practice of Jeremiah is an invitation to seek for language that is passionate, dangerous, and imaginative enough to make available the passion, danger and freedom of God who summons us to God's own conflict. It is always a practice of such prophetic poetry to break the conventions in which we habituate God. The dulled God of the conventional religious traditions will never yield energy for ministry. But this poetry gives us hints and permissions about bringing this conflict-making God to speech. Otherwise, we may miss the conflict which is our poetic, prophetic vocation.[29]

If Jeremiah's prophetic ministry is any indication, to participate in the Spirit's work is not to rest comfortably in a stable and predictable environment. It is rather to open oneself up to a radical form of disruption, inviting the Spirit to break the conventions in which we habituate the divine, and, in doing so, to bring this conflict-making God to speech.

The Spirit Decenters

The Spirit's disruptive work is particularly unsettling for those who are located at or near centers of power. A case in point is King Josiah's stand against a foreign adversary. One of Judah's good kings (2 Chron. 34:2), Josiah is best known for the various reforms he

instituted during his reign. Second Chronicles 35:20–27 tells the story of Josiah's death, which begins when Neco, the king of Egypt, attempts to cross through Israel on his way to battle another nation. Rather than allowing the Egyptian army to pass through peacefully, Josiah intercepts Neco, which prompts the Egyptian pharaoh to ask, "What have I to do with you, king of Judah? I am not coming against you today, but against the house with which I am at war; and God has commanded me to hurry. Cease opposing God, who is with me, so that he will not destroy you" (2 Chron. 35:21 NRSV). According to the text, Josiah refuses to "listen to the words of Neco from the mouth of God" (2 Chron. 35:22 NRSV) and, as a consequence, dies from the wounds he incurs in battle, just as Neco said he would.

Again, this story is nothing if not disturbing, especially for those who identify as members of the community of faith. But that's just as it should be. After all, if anyone has the right to speak for God, surely it's the good and faithful king ruling over Yahweh's covenant community and not the king of a brutal and marauding nation like Egypt. Yet, as Josiah's story suggests, even the chosen people of God are not always (or perhaps ever?) the center around which the Spirit's operations revolve. As it turns out, Josiah's failure to realize that the initiatives of the faithful do not stand at the center of God's activity in the world was not simply a misstep; it was, in a very real sense, to actively oppose God (v. 21). In this way, Josiah's story is not unique. To borrow again from Taylor, the Spirit repeatedly "goes to great lengths to teach a particular tribe that it is God's chosen people, only to reveal to them that other nations have known the same salvation-history: 'Are you Israelites not like Cushites to me? Says the Lord. Did I not bring Israel up from Egypt, the Philistines from Caphtor, the Arameans from Kir?' (Amos 9:7)."[30]

Biblical stories like these suggest that the Spirit's decentering work operates on at least two levels. On the corporate level, the Spirit upends the unjust power structures of religious communities, nation-states, and the powerful elite who lead them. But, just as Josiah discovered, the Spirit also decenters each of us on an individual

level, reconfiguring our personal sense of self. Needless to say, interacting with the Spirit in this way can be painful. In Josiah's case, it was fatal, in large part because, just like us, Josiah lived as if his personal identity (as the king of God's chosen people) was a possession as well as a position, something that had to be pried from his hands. Moving in quite the opposite direction, the Spirit perpetually calls, invites, and even persuades us to locate the center of our personal identity not "within" ourselves but "outside" ourselves—to receive it as a gift from God.

Clinical psychologist Richard Beck refers to this kind of decentered sense of self as an "eccentric identity," which he argues was the defining characteristic of Jesus's life. Following the work of Arthur McGill, Beck suggests that Jesus's identity was the product of his complete and utter reliance on the decentering Spirit of God.

> The center of Jesus' reality is not within Jesus himself. Everything that happens to him, everything that is done by him, including his death, is displaced to another context and is thereby reinterpreted. However, this portrayal is understood to be a true reflection of Jesus' own way of existing. He himself does not live out of himself. He lives, so to speak, from beyond himself. Jesus does not confront his followers as a center which reveals himself. He confronts them as always revealing what is beyond him.[31]

For Beck, then, the key to Jesus's identity is that he didn't actually possess it; instead, he received it as a gift. Animated at every turn by the Spirit, Jesus lived a fully decentered life. And we are invited to do the same. On both the corporate and personal level, we participate with the Spirit's decentering work any time we too embrace an eccentric identity—a deep sense of self that is anchored not merely outside of ourselves, but ultimately, in God.

The Spirit Disperses

Whether guiding the people of Israel through the wilderness (Exod. 13:21), leading Jesus into the desert (Matt. 4:1), or prompting the apostles to bear witness to the gospel in "Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the farthest parts of the earth"

(Acts 1:8), the Spirit of God not only animates, disrupts, and decenters, but disperses the human spirit as well. This kind of scattering is another form of disruption, but its principal orientation is outward (toward the world) rather than inward (toward the self). This is to say, as *hevel* gives way to *ruach*, the Spirit of God moves us into places and spaces that, if we're being honest, we would likely never have chosen ourselves. To be sure, this kind of movement is almost always uncomfortable, in large part because it is quite literally an unsettling. But that's just what it means to be inspired or, better yet, in-spirited. It is to join in with the movement of the Divine Breath of Life that cannot be contained or coerced and, in many cases, is thoroughly unpredictable. As Jesus would remind us, "The wind blows wherever it will, and you hear the sound it makes, but do not know where it comes from and where it is going. So it is with everyone who is born of the Spirit" (John 3:8).

As the risk-averse creatures that we are, we tend to shy away from such unpredictability in favor of something more certain and reliable. But this resistance to the unknown merely exposes how stagnant and settled we've become, how prone we are to retreating into the safety and comfort of the known. Thus, to participate with the Spirit as Jesus, the apostles, and the people of Israel once did is not to avoid or run away from being radically unsettled. It is to run headlong into an unpredictable future filled with equal parts risk and excitement, knowing full well that the Spirit of God will be present with us, ushering us into places that we could never have asked for or imagined (Eph. 3:20) and, in doing so, transforming us.

Cultivating Space Where *Ruach* and *Hevel* Meet

As theologically imaginative as all this talk of the Spirit as the breath of life may be, some may be wondering what exactly this has to do with John, the young man we met earlier who is seeking professional help for his mental health. From a theological perspective, what does it mean for a person like John to experience healing, growth, or transformation if he never comes to a saving knowledge of Christ? Doesn't the entire Christian tradition hinge on

the confession of the resurrected Christ as humanity's only true hope for healing and restoration? If so, can we really speak of John's life being renewed, much less him flourishing, if Christ's redemptive work is never even considered? As Ezekiel 18:23 points out, it pleases God even when the wicked turn from their destructive patterns of death and instead choose life, so surely the same is true for a person like John. At the very least, God desires for John to experience a life of wholeness and well-being because John, like every human, is part of God's good creation. But is that all we can say? Could it be that, perhaps, the Spirit of God is not merely pleased with John's journey but is in fact actively and passionately involved in his life as the source of his healing, whether explicitly acknowledged or not?

Others may have more general concerns, wondering how this notion of the Spirit ought to inform our understanding of the ways in which humans are able to collaborate with God's activity in any domain (e.g., the therapeutic context) that is not explicitly Christian, religious, or even theistic. Given that people really do get better in therapy, how do we make sense of this as Christians, especially when it involves people who are not Christians and Christ is never mentioned? In the next chapter, we will examine the relational dimension of these questions, considering more fully the ways in which healing happens in and through relationships. But we will also take up these questions in more depth and detail in part 2 of the book, where we will explore the various ways in which the Spirit's work impacts and, in a very real sense, makes possible the work that takes place in the context of psychotherapy.

For now, building on the image of a dissipated mist, it will be enough to say that to participate with the Spirit of God is simply to have the courage to enter the space where *ruach* and *hevel* meet, allowing our human spirit to give way to the Spirit of God. In these spaces, our task is not to exert control over the chaos of our lives or the lives of others. Our task is simply to submit to a force at work in the world that not only energizes and in-spirits us but also disrupts, scatters, and undoes us. As the biblical testimony makes clear, this

process can be as unsettling as it is inspiring, and it almost always moves us in surprising and unexpected ways.

Yet, beyond a simple willingness to enter a potentially disruptive space, a robust pneumatology like the one we have outlined suggests that the primary objective for the student of psychology is to focus on developing their skills at *creating* such spaces—growing in their capacity to cultivate environments where they and their clients can together inhale and exhale God's life-giving breath.[32] To underscore the level of humility required for this endeavor, it is important to keep in mind that the divine *ruach* is always already blowing in and through our client's lives. So our role in curating these spaces has almost nothing to do with leveraging our power or resources or ingenuity; rather, it's about joining in the divine movement that was already in motion long before we joined in and will continue long after our contributions come to an end.

In this regard, we appreciate Moltmann's perspective. For Moltmann, *ruach* is not only a personal presence but also the transcendent space in which we live "in" God's Spirit. Just as God provides the psalmist the ability to stand out of harm's way in "a wide open place" (Ps. 31:8), we experience the presence of God's *ruach* as the space in which we "live and move and have our being" (Acts 17:28 NRSV). In this space, *ruach* is the most silent and hidden presence of God's Spirit, for it is both in us and around us. Ultimately then, for us to collaborate with God's *ruach* is to cultivate spaces where we do not simply talk *about* the Spirit, but where we talk *out of* the Spirit.[33] In other words, it is to create space where we can come together in unexpected places, forge unexpected friendships, and simply breathe.

Questions for Reflection and Discussion

1. How have pastors, parents, and other Christian leaders in your life addressed the biblical passages referenced in this chapter (if at all)? Has our discussion of these passages changed the way you understand God's broader work in the world?
2. If the Spirit of God is to humans what an author is to the fictional characters in a novel, what does this mean for the various projects we pursue (psychological or otherwise)?
3. How does the image of *ruach* and *hevel* support or challenge your understanding of God's involvement in your life's work?
4. What would it look like, in concrete terms, for you to participate in the Spirit's work of animation, disruption, decentering, and dispersal?

Resources for Reading and Exploration

Beck, Richard. *The Slavery of Death*. Eugene, OR: Cascade Books, 2014.

Johnston, Robert K. *God's Wider Presence: Reconsidering General Revelation.* Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2014.

Pargament, Kenneth I. *Spiritually Integrated Psychotherapy: Understanding and Addressing the Sacred.* New York: Guilford Press, 2007.

1. American Psychological Association, "Ethical Principles of Psychologists and Code of Conduct," 2017, https://www.apa.org/ethics/code.

2. Our colleagues at Fuller Seminary, Dr. Siang-Yang Tan, Dr. Brad Strawn, and Dr. Pamela Ebstyne-King, are notable exceptions to this rule.

3. Kenneth I. Pargament, *Spiritually Integrated Psychotherapy: Understanding and Addressing the Sacred* (New York: Guilford Press, 2007), 8.

4. Pargament cites two key studies suggesting that "only 18% of the directors [of counseling psychology programs in the United States] indicated that their graduate programs offered a course that focused on religion or spirituality (Schulte, Skinner, & Claiborn, 2002). Only 13% of training directors of clinical psychology programs in the United States and Canada reported that

their curriculum included a course on religion and spirituality (Brawer, Handal, Fabricatore, Roberts, & Wajda-Johnston, 2002)." *Spiritually Integrated Psychotherapy*, 9.

5. An odd sort of disciplinary ambivalence has emerged. As Steven J. Sandage and Jeannine K. Brown point out, "During the past forty years, the fields of psychology and psychotherapy have experienced a profound shift on the topics of 'religion' and 'spirituality,' even as the formal disciplines of theology and religious studies remain largely marginalized within psychology." *Relational Integration*, 30.

6. See David A. Steere, *Spiritual Presence in Psychotherapy: A Guide for Caregivers* (New York: Routledge, 2018).

7. We are by no means the first to make this claim about the Spirit's presence in the midst of therapy. See, for example, the excellent work of Siang-Yang Tan in *Counseling and Psychotherapy: A Christian Perspective* (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2011); and Siang-Yang Tan and Douglas H. Gregg, *Disciplines of the Holy Spirit: How to Connect to the Spirit's Power and Presence* (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 1997). Our goal here is not to introduce an entirely novel concept that is without precedent, but rather to develop a constructive theology of the Spirit that might fill some gaps in the current literature and offer a more robust series of theological and biblical resources for psychologists (and psychologists in training) hoping to answer the question of how their work as clinicians relates to God's larger project in the world.

8. Even though this book is concerned primarily with developing a more robust way of doing constructive theology and not so much with "integration" per se, the question of how the therapist participates with God's ongoing mission in the world through the work of clinical psychology reflects the leading edge of the current integration conversation. See, for example, Megan Anna Neff and Mark R. McMinn, *Embodying Integration: A Fresh Look at Christianity in the Therapy Room* (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2020). Indeed, Neff and McMinn conclude their text by raising the same question we are exploring: What is God up to in the world?

9. Calvin's work on the topic was expansive and robust. As a consequence, many of the Reformed theologians writing in the shadow of Calvin have been in an ongoing argument regarding who is most faithful, not so much to the biblical text but to Calvin.

10. We owe this turn of phrase to Robert K. Johnston, "The Mystery Discerning Business," in *Don't Stop Believin': Pop Culture and Religion from Ben Hur to Zombies*, ed. Robert K. Johnston, Craig Detweiler, and Barry Taylor (Louisville: Westminster John Knox Press, 2012), 211–12.

11. This captures much of the core argument outlined by G. C. Berkouwer, *General Revelation* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1955); and Bruce A. Demarest,

General Revelation: Historical Views and Contemporary Issues (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 1982).

12. See Emil Brunner and Karl Barth, *Natural Theology: Comprising "Nature and Grace"* (London: Centenary Press, 1946).

13. Even though Barth overstated his case, he was right. The German church's acquiescence to Hitler's rise to power was, in no small part, due to a natural theology that had no need for God's active agency in the human pursuit of knowledge about God. In this respect, Ludwig Feuerbach's famous critique in *The Essence of Christianity* was shown to be true: "God" is just "human" shouted loudly.

14. We would like to acknowledge our indebtedness for this phrasing to Robert K. Johnston, *God's Wider Presence: Reconsidering General Revelation* (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2014). Because Johnston's book interacts with, draws from, and, indeed, builds on our previous work on this topic, it is encouraging to see that the theological discourse in which we have played a small part is now serving as the theological and biblical touchstone for those exploring the question of how the practice of clinical psychology relates to the presence and activity of God in the world. A recent example of psychologists who explicitly cite Johnston's notion of God's wider presence as their theological starting point are Steven J. Sandage and Jeannine K. Brown, *Relational Integration of Psychology and Christian Theology: Theory, Research, and Practice* (New York: Routledge, 2018), 94–95.

15. The bulk of the conversation between Barth and Brunner focuses on the possibility (or lack thereof) of this "point of contact." See Barth and Brunner, *Natural Theology*.

16. Martin Buber, *I and Thou*, trans. Ronald Gregor Smith (Mansfield Centre, CT: Martino, 2010).

17. In his commentary on Romans, Barth was particularly influenced by Søren Kierkegaard's notion of an "infinite qualitative" difference or distinction between God and humanity. See Søren Kierkegaard, *Training in Christianity and the Edifying Discourse Which "Accompanied" It*, trans. Walter Lowrie (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1941), 139.

18. Johnston, *God's Wider Presence*, 127–28 (emphasis added).

19. Robert Jewett, *Saint Paul at the Movies: The Apostle's Dialogue with American Culture* (Louisville: Westminster John Knox, 1993), 65–76.

20. Two recent examples of evolutionary psychologists making claims along these lines are Michael Tomasello, *Becoming Human: A Theory of Ontogeny* (Cambridge, MA: Belknap Press, 2019); and Robert Boyd, *A Different Kind of Animal: How Culture Transformed Our Species* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2018).

21. Makoto Fujimura, *Culture Care: Reconnecting with Beauty for Our Common Life* (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Books, 2017), 22.

22. Jürgen Moltmann, *The Spirit of Life: A Universal Affirmation*, trans. Margaret Kohl (Minneapolis: Fortress, 1992), 41.

23. Moltmann, *The Spirit of Life*, 82.

24. We don't have the space to unpack this philosophically and theologically loaded claim. For those who are interested in the implications of such a view, we point readers to Nancey Murphy's excellent *Bodies and Souls, or Spirited Bodies?* Current Issues in Theology (Cambridge, MA: Cambridge University Press, 2006).

25. We have covered elsewhere much of what we are outlining here regarding the Hebrew concepts of *hevel* and *ruach*. See, e.g., Kutter Callaway, *Scoring Transcendence: Contemporary Film Music as Religious Experience* (Waco: Baylor University Press, 2013), 162–71. That being said, we were pleasantly surprised to discover that Megan Anna Neff and Mark R. McMinn also find the image of *hevel* helpful for thinking about our contemporary world. For anyone interested in a more developed account of how the book of Ecclesiastes can serve as a much-needed conversation partner for those engaged in clinical psychology, we highly recommend their book, *Embodying Integration: A Fresh Look at Christianity in the Therapy Room* (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2020).

26. We owe this particular way of thinking about the interaction between *hevel* and *ruach* to Jean-Luc Marion, *God without Being*, 2nd ed., trans. Thomas A. Carlson (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2012).

27. The theological term most often used to describe this internal structuring by the Spirit is "immanent transcendence."

28. John Vernon Taylor, *The Go-Between God: The Holy Spirit and the Christian Mission* (London: SCM, 2004).

29. Walter Breuggemann, *Hopeful Imagination: Prophetic Voices in Exile* (Philadelphia: Fortress, 1986), 15.

30. Taylor, *Go-Between God*, 179.

31. Richard Beck, *The Slavery of Death* (Eugene, OR: Cascade Books, 2013), 70. Here Beck is quoting from Arthur C. McGill, *Death and Life: An American Theology* (Eugene, OR: Wipf & Stock, 2003), 49–50.

32. Megan Anna Neff echoes this sentiment when she recounts an experience she had with one of her clients:

> My work with Brooke was humbling and awe provoking in that I quickly realized I was just one piece of *the work God was already up to in her life*. . . . There is no sophisticated model for integration at play here; what I needed to do with Brooke *was simply to create a space* of acceptance that allowed for God's presence while having ears to hear when she talked

about her spiritual life. God was with us in the therapy room each week, and God continued to be with Brooke in the intervening times through her relationships, in church, in nature, and through prayer. (Neff and McMinn, *Embodying Integration,* 180, emphasis added)

33. Moltmann, *Spirit of Life*, 57.